

RHETORICAL QUESTIONS

Questions asked for effect, not for an answer



1 What is it?

Rhetorical Questions (ri-TOR-ih-kul KWES-chuns)

A rhetorical question is asked **to make a point**, not to get a real answer — it forces the reader or listener to think, agree, or feel challenged.

a question + no answer expected

2 See it in action

Persuasive speech

"Are we really going to let this happen?" the speaker demanded.

In advertising

"Tired of wasting money on ads that don't work?"

Everyday speech

"Can you believe this weather?" she sighed, shaking her head.

Building guilt

"Is this really how you want to be remembered?"



Look here!

Check the context: is the writer actually **waiting for a reply**, or clearly expecting the reader to just nod along? That tells you if it's rhetorical.

FUN FACT

Rhetorical questions are a cornerstone of classical rhetoric, used by Ancient Greek and Roman speakers over 2,000 years ago — and politicians and advertisers still lean on the exact same trick today.

3 Why writers use it

Rhetorical Questions help writers: engage the reader directly, make them feel involved in the argument, guide them toward a particular conclusion without stating it outright, and add emotional pressure.

It's an especially powerful persuasive device — instead of TELLING the reader what to think, it makes them feel like they came up with the answer themselves.

4 Where you'll spot it

Charity adverts

"How would you feel if this happened to your family?" — designed to make viewers reflect.

Debate & argument

Used to challenge an opponent's point without directly attacking them.



Watch out!

Don't confuse a rhetorical question with a genuine one asked in dialogue! If a character is actually expecting a reply, it's just a normal question, not a rhetorical device.



You got this!

Rhetorical questions often appear in **clusters of three** in persuasive speeches — spotting the pattern is worth mentioning in your analysis.

5 Quick recap

A question with no real answer expected

Makes the reader think

Common in persuasive writing



Good spot!

Try turning a plain statement into a rhetorical question — "This is unfair" becomes "**Is this really fair?**" — notice how much more persuasive it feels.